

Disabling Viewstate's MAC: why you deserve having now a broken ASP.NET web application

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Content

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[Lots of things happened since my first \(and unique\) blog post about ASP.NET Viewstate and its related weakness](#). This blog post will not yet disclose all the details or contain tools to exploit applications, but give some ideas why it's really mandatory to both correct your web applications and install the ASP.NET patch.

Back in September 2012 I reported an issue in the ASP.NET framework which could be used to potentially execute remote code in a typical SharePoint installation. Microsoft patched its flagship products [SharePoint](#) and [Outlook Web Access](#). They also released guidance in [security advisory 2905247 which contained an optional patch to download](#), removing the ASP.NET framework's ability to alter setting "EnableViewStateMac". It was also made clear that [Microsoft will forbid this setting in upcoming ASP.NET versions](#). ASP.NET version 4.5.2, released in May 2014, [was the first version of ASP.NET to have this setting disabled](#). Microsoft released [as part of this month's Patch Tuesday](#) a patch to remove [support for setting EnableViewStateMac for all ASP.NET versions](#).

While [this patch may break ASP.NET applications](#), remember that without this patch you're vulnerable to a much bigger threat. Fixing the web application is in the very vast majority of the cases easy from a technical perspective (e.g. set up dedicated machine keys within a given web farm). But as pointed out in the [ASP.NET article](#), the management and distribution of these machine keys must follow a strict process to avoid being disclosed to unwanted parties. Think of machine keys being an essential element of your application. If

these keys have ever been disclosed, you have to change them immediately. Ensure software purchased or downloaded from the Internet does not contain pre-defined keys in the application's web.config.

If you want to know more but [missed my Area41 talk about this flaw](#), come over to the [App Sec Forum Western Switzerland on November 4th to 6th in Yverdon-les-Bains](#). I will be presenting an updated version of my "Why .NET needs MACs and other serial(-ization) tales" talk about the underlying flaws, their history and how to exploit them.

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